

AGE OF THE PIONEERS

1

HAVING SPENT CENTURIES WATCHING BIRDS with admiration and envy, when humans eventually took to the air – in the late 18th century – it was, in fact, in a balloon rather than on the wing. Nevertheless, the desire to soar through the air like a bird remained. In the course of the 19th century, scientists and inventors worked on the basic principles of flight, experimenting with gliders and ungainly steam-powered flying machines and models. But it took the persistent efforts of the Wright brothers, in experiments between 1899 and 1905, to finally achieve practical powered airplane flight. The period up to 1914 brought spectacular progress. The public was enthralled by long-distance flying races and displays of aerobatics, while new speed and altitude records were posted yearly, although at the cost of the lives of many early aviators.



TENTATIVE TAKEOFF

In sand dunes on the shores of Lake Michigan, in the summer of 1896, assistants of American flight pioneer Octave Chanute experiment with a triplane glider. As a result of these experiments, Chanute produced the most influential glider of the pre-Wright era.